another offensive in May 2006, this time against the Sri Lankan navy. A vessel was destroyed and the Tigers fired upon other patrolling units, making the sea a new theatre of civil war. Kosala said that the European Union agreed with the Sri Lankan government's demand to declare the LTTE a terrorist outfit. On 19 May 2006, LTTE assets on foreign soil were frozen on the grounds that the terror outfit did not represent Tamils in Sri Lanka.

Running out of Time

The R&AW was increasingly worried over the safety of Tamils who had made Sri Lanka their home for the last many decades. In late 2006, a diplomatic dispatch from Colombo put the number of ethnic Tamils at thirty thousand while the R&AW told their chief P.K.H. Tharakan that at least one hundred and sixty thousand Tamils were caught in the crossfire. Avinash said that the R&AW had penetrated Sri Lanka's northern province deeply, especially districts like Jaffna, Vavu-niya, Kilinochchi and Mannar.

'Our assessment was solid and as the war loomed large over the horizon, our primary objective was to evacuate as many Tamils as possible. But that was just a foggy dream. Under tremendous pressure from the Tigers, the Tamil populations had decided to remain and we couldn't do anything about it,' said Avinash.

The Indian government had taken a principled decision to support the Sri Lankan army offensive because the entire international community had been outraged by the LTTE's string of suicide bombings. According to Avinash, between late 2007 and May 2009 when Sri Lanka declared total victory against the LTTE, the R&AW provided satellite imagery of all the Tigers' camps in the north and east provinces to the Sri